

Your relationship with your midwife is even more important if you're giving birth at home as she will be your sole medical support.

ASK A MIDWIFE

What additional things do I need to think about if I'm having a home birth? Have all the items you need for labor and birth gathered in the place you intend to deliver, and organize your items separately from the baby's items.

As well as practical items, such as clothing, toiletries, and sanitary pads, you may also want to have on hand music, phone numbers, and a camera. It's a good idea to have a well-stocked fridge, so make a list of nutritious foods to stock up on before your due date. This will help you during labor and in the first week of parenthood. Your baby will need diapers, cotton cloths, onesies, clothing, sheets, blankets, and a hat.

If you have other children, you may need to make arrangements for them to be taken care of.

Even though you're planning to have your baby at home, there are circumstances in which you may need to be transferred to the hospital. You should have an emergency bag packed (see [Items for your hospital bag](#)) just in case.

GROUP B STREP TEST

Ten to 30 percent of pregnant women carry the strep B bacteria in the vagina or rectal area. Known as group B streptococcus (GBS), it is usually harmless in adults, but can cause a rare and serious infection in newborn babies if untreated.

- Many women are now routinely screened for GBS, at 35–37 weeks of pregnancy. If the result is positive, antibiotic treatment can be given during labor that will reduce the risk of the baby becoming infected. Some hospitals don't screen but if the bacteria is detected in a urine test or a swab is taken for another reason and is positive, antibiotic treatment may given in labor.
- The test involves taking a swab of the area around your vagina and rectum.
- If treatment is given as soon as labour starts, there is little risk to the baby.
- It is possible to be infected with GBS in a second pregnancy, even if you didn't have it first time around.